Lesson 49: Sentence Variety for Style; The Style Toolkit

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 6.12 Using Sentence Variety; 6.13 Language Toolkit; 6.14 Takeaways.

In this lesson

You will review the four sentence types and use them to make your writing livelier and to show clearly how your ideas are related. You will punctuate coordination and subordination correctly, count and revise the sentence types in a student's paragraph, and use the chapter's Language Toolkit to check your drafts. Varied, well-connected sentences make an academic argument easier to follow.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Identify simple, compound, complex and compound-complex sentences.
- Join independent clauses with a coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS) or with a semicolon and a transition, and punctuate them correctly.
- Join a dependent clause to an independent clause and decide whether a comma is needed.
- Revise a paragraph for sentence variety and emphasis, using the Language Toolkit as a checklist.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
independent clause	a subject and a verb that express a complete thought; it can stand alone	California is one of the world's leading almond producers.
dependent (subordinate) clause	a subject and a verb that do not express a complete thought	although the state is dry for much of the year
coordination	joining two independent clauses with related ideas of equal importance	a compound sentence
subordination	joining a dependent clause to an independent clause, so that one idea gets more emphasis	a complex sentence
coordinating conjunction	for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so (FANBOYS)	…, and each year California exports many of its almonds.
subordinating conjunction	a word that begins a dependent clause	although, even though, since, because, when
transition	a word or phrase that shows the logic between two clauses or sentences	as a result, however, moreover

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
sentence variety	using different sentence types, lengths and rhythms	Sentence variety can help maintain your readers' interest.
monotony	dull sameness	Writers avoid monotony by varying their sentence structures.

Rules and explanations

Four sentence types

Type	Structure	The book's example
Simple	one independent clause	California is one of the world's leading almond producers.
Compound (coordination)	two independent clauses of equal importance	California is one of the world's leading almond producers, and each year California exports many of its almonds.
Complex (subordination)	one independent clause + one or more dependent clauses	California is one of the world's leading almond producers although the state is dry for much of the year.
Compound-complex	at least two independent clauses + one or more dependent clauses	Although it is dry for much of the year, California is one of the world's leading almond producers; each year, it supplies about 80% of the world's almonds.

- In a complex sentence, the idea you want to emphasize usually goes in the **independent clause**. (Your material says the almond sentence "emphasizes that demand for water is increasing". This is a slip: its independent clause, and so its emphasis, is that California is a leading almond producer.)
- A dependent clause can also begin with **who**, **that** or **which** (a relative clause), and it also makes a sentence complex.

Joining two independent clauses

1. Comma + coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS)

Logic	Conjunction	Logic	Conjunction
cause	for	contrast	but, yet
addition	and	choice or alternative	or
negative alternative	nor	effect	so

Put a comma before the conjunction only when it joins two clauses, not when it joins two words or phrases. After **nor**, the auxiliary verb comes before the subject, as in a question.

2. Semicolon + transition + comma "There was a shortage of PPE in 2020**; as a result,** farmworkers did not have access to important protective equipment." (PPE = personal protective equipment)

Logic	Transitions (Toolkit table)
Addition	also, furthermore, moreover, similarly, likewise
Contrast	instead, however, otherwise
Emphasis	namely, certainly, indeed
Cause and effect	accordingly, as a result, consequently, hence, thus, therefore
Time	finally, next, subsequently, then
Condition	otherwise
Choice or alternative	alternatively, on the other hand, conversely

(The Toolkit introduces this table as "subordinating conjunctions", but these words are transitions. Its Time row also lists "after", which is a subordinating conjunction or preposition; the transition is "afterward".)

Joining a dependent clause to an independent clause

- Subordinating conjunctions include **although, even though, since, because, when**.
- **Dependent clause first: use a comma.** Although it is dry for much of the year**,** California is...
- **Dependent clause second: no comma.** California is one of the world's leading almond producers although the state is dry...

Varying your sentences

- Writing with mostly simple sentences can be repetitive and boring, and it may lack the transitions that show how ideas are related.
- Mix lengths and rhythms. Use parallel structures for parallel ideas, but vary your structures to avoid monotony.
- A very short sentence in a paragraph can emphasize an idea.
- When you revise, ask: Are my sentences mostly simple? Mostly compound? Or varied?

The Style Toolkit: a checklist for your drafts

Check	Before	After
Strong verbs: a weak verb ("be", "do", "have") + noun becomes one verb	We have a strong belief in food equity.	We strongly believe in food equity.
Clear pronouns (it, they, this, these...)	...can take longer to prepare. This is a potential disadvantage.	...These factors are potential disadvantages.
Active voice	The lettuce was washed thoroughly by her aunt.	Her aunt washed the lettuce thoroughly.
Connotation	Not sure a word fits?	Look it up in example sentences on the internet, or ask your tutor.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic texts often join many clauses with "wa" (and) or "fa" (so, then). In English, a long chain of "and" clauses sounds unplanned: use subordinating conjunctions and transitions to show the exact relationship, and keep some sentences short. - A comma alone cannot join two independent clauses in English (a comma splice). Use a comma + FANBOYS, or a semicolon + transition + comma.

Practice

Exercise 1. Notice this. In the lesson material, read Amanda's excerpt of five short sentences ("The lack of accessibility and affordability may obstruct...") and the revised version ("Although the lack of accessibility...").

1. What do you notice about the words and phrases in the original?
2. Which version do you prefer? Why?
3. What type of sentence is the revised version?

Exercise 2. Sentence types. Is each sentence simple, compound, complex or compound-complex?

1. Fresh foods are often more expensive and can take longer to prepare.
2. People who live in food deserts cannot access healthy food.
3. Because the United States was unprepared for a pandemic, there was a shortage of PPE in 2020; as a result, farmworkers did not have access to important protective equipment.
4. On Tuesdays Mandela Foods delivers fresh fruits and vegetables to corner stores in West Oakland; otherwise, people have to travel a great distance to buy produce.
5. These resources include food hubs and community gardens.
6. Organic grocery stores seem to be everywhere, but it's still hard for many people to access them.
7. Public transportation can be unreliable, so if you buy a gallon of milk and take the bus, the milk may spoil by the time you get home.

Exercise 3. Punctuation. Add commas and semicolons where they are needed. Write "no comma" if none is needed.

1. When you revise a piece of writing consider the patterns of your sentences.
2. Using a dictionary or thesaurus can be difficult sometimes if you don't know the connotations of a word because you risk using a word in the wrong way.
3. If you aren't sure whether you are using a word with the right connotation look up the word in sentences on the internet and see how it's used in context.
4. People have begun paying more attention to the health benefits of organic foods and it is no surprise that many grocery stores have expanded their organic sections.
5. Community gardens are one solution to food deserts on the other hand it's not always realistic that people will have the time and energy to grow food for themselves.

Exercise 4. Coordinating conjunctions. Complete each sentence from the Toolkit with a FANBOYS conjunction that shows the logic in brackets.

1. Many Americans suffer from hunger, _____ food scarcity is a serious social issue in this country. (cause)
2. The neighborhood has never had a grocery store, _____ has it had a community garden. (negative alternative)
3. California is suffering from a catastrophic drought, _____ most of the nation's produce is grown here. (contrast)
4. Some environmental experts have commented that California's water supply can support its population, _____ it can support its agriculture -- but not both. (choice)

Exercise 5. Transitions. Join each pair into one sentence with a semicolon, a transition that shows the logic in brackets, and a comma.

1. Community gardens are places that allow people to provide food for themselves. This food is frequently more nutritious than what can be bought at grocery stores. (addition)
2. Research on Google Maps shows that there are at least ten corner liquor stores in West Oakland. There are no supermarkets like Whole Foods. (contrast)
3. It is important to draw attention to food inequity. Many people are unaware that it exists at such high levels in the United States. (emphasis)
4. There are insufficient outlets for fresh food in their community. It's hard for residents of West Oakland who live in food deserts to access healthy produce. (cause and effect)
5. First, we are going to take a survey of the neighborhood's needs. We can write a proposal. (time)

Exercise 6. Try this: identifying sentence variety. Read the paragraph about City Slicker Farms in the lesson material ("The goal of City Slicker Farms is...").

1. Count the simple, compound, complex and compound-complex sentences. Is there a balance? (The book's question names "Alicia"; it means Amanda.)
2. Change the structure of one or two sentences, for example by combining two simple sentences with a subordinating conjunction.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is a paragraph from my essay: [paste]. Count my sentence types, then suggest two changes that would improve the variety and the emphasis."
- "Give me six pairs of short sentences about a psychology topic, such as sleep or memory. I will join each pair with FANBOYS, a transition or a subordinating conjunction. Check the logic and the punctuation."
- "Ask me the questions for reflection in the Takeaways one by one, for example: What are some factors that contribute to the tone of a piece of writing? Give me feedback on each answer."
- "Let's look back at Amanda's food deserts essay. What does she do well in clarity, style and tone, and what would you recommend she improve?"

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each |, and let your voice rise a little before the comma after a dependent clause.

1. Although it is dry for much of the year, | California is one of the world's leading almond producers; | each year, | it supplies about 80% of the world's almonds.
2. There was a shortage of PPE in 2020; | as a result, | farmworkers did not have access to important protective equipment.
3. Organic grocery stores seem to be everywhere, | but it's still hard for many people to access them.
4. Sentence variety can help maintain your readers' interest.

Writing task

Apply this. Take a paragraph of 200-250 words that you are working on, or write a new one on a psychology topic (why sleep matters for memory, or how the food environment shapes eating habits, from the PSYC 110 guest lecture on food). Count its sentence types, then revise it for variety and emphasis. Keep both versions.

Include each sentence type, a FANBOYS conjunction, a semicolon + transition, and one short sentence that emphasizes a key idea.

Self-editing checklist:

- Is there a balance of simple, compound, complex and compound-complex sentences?
- Does each connector show the right logic (cause, contrast, addition, effect...)?
- Is there a comma before FANBOYS only when it joins two clauses?
- Does a semicolon come before, and a comma after, each transition that joins two clauses?
- Is there a comma after a dependent clause that comes first, and none before one that comes second?
- Is my most important idea in an independent clause?
- Toolkit: strong verbs, clear pronouns, active voice where possible?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1 (example answer)

1. The sentences are short and separate, and almost all start with the subject. Words repeat ("food deserts", "resources"), there are no transitions, and the text sounds choppy. (The book calls all five "simple sentences"; strictly, the two with relative clauses, "who live in food deserts" and "that they can make good use of", are complex.)
2. Most readers prefer the revised version: "Although" shows the contrast between the problem and the solution, and "who live in food deserts" and "such as" join the ideas smoothly in one fluent sentence.
3. Complex: the dependent clause "Although the lack of accessibility and affordability may obstruct… access to healthy food" + the independent clause "they can make good use of existing resources…".

Exercise 2

1. simple (one subject with two verbs, "are" and "can take")
2. complex ("who live in food deserts" is a dependent clause)
3. compound-complex
4. compound (semicolon + transition)
5. simple
6. compound
7. compound-complex (two independent clauses joined by "so", plus the dependent clauses "if you buy… the bus" and "by the time you get home")

Exercise 3

1. …a piece of writing, consider… (dependent clause first)
2. no comma (both dependent clauses come after the independent clause)
3. …the right connotation, look up… (no comma before "and see": it joins two verbs)
4. …organic foods, and it is no surprise… (two independent clauses)
5. …food deserts; on the other hand, it's not always realistic…

Exercise 4

1. for
2. nor
3. yet (but is also correct)
4. or

Exercise 5 (the transitions in brackets are also correct; not every word in a row of the table fits every sentence: for example, instead and otherwise do not fit item 2, and namely does not fit item 3)

1. …for themselves; moreover, this food… (or furthermore, also)
2. …in West Oakland; however, there are no supermarkets like Whole Foods.

3. ...food inequity; indeed, many people are unaware...
4. ...in their community; therefore, it's hard... (or as a result, consequently, thus, accordingly)
5. ...the neighborhood's needs; then, we can write a proposal. (or next, subsequently)

Exercise 6

1. Seven sentences: five simple (sentences 1, 2, 3, 6 and 7), no compound, two complex, no compound-complex. There is no balance: simple sentences dominate. The complex ones are sentence 4 ("If residents can make good use of food hubs or community gardens, they can...") and sentence 5 ("The earlier case study showed that the difficulties... are...", where a "that" clause and a "who" clause depend on the main clause).
2. (example answer) "Residents receive plots of land to plant vegetables and fruits, and they are also encouraged to exchange and discuss their gardening experiences at the farm." (compound) "Although these factors may not be easy to change, recognizing the situation and making good use of existing resources to access healthy food are significant, feasible steps." (complex)

My notes